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Regular Expressions Cookbook, 2nd Edition by Jan Goyvaerts, Steven Le...

9.5. Convert Plain Text to HTML by Adding `<p>` and `<br>` Tags

Problem

Given a plain text string, such as a multiline value submitted via a form, you want to convert it to an HTML fragment to display within a web page. Paragraphs, separated by two line breaks in a row, should be surrounded with `<p>...</p>`. Additional line breaks should be replaced with `<br>` tags.

Solution

This problem can be solved in four simple steps. In most programming languages, only the middle two steps benefit from regular expressions.

Step 1: Replace HTML special characters with named character references

As we're converting plain text to HTML, the first step is to convert the three special HTML characters `&`, `<`, and `>` to named character references (see [Table 9-3](#)). Otherwise, the resulting

Table 9-3 HTML special character substitutions

Search for	Replace with
<&>	«&»
<<>	«<»
<>>	«>»

Ampersands (&) must be replaced first, since you’ll be adding more ampersands to the subject string as part of the named character references.

Step 2: Replace all line breaks with

Search for:

\r\n?|\n

Regex options: None

Regex flavors: .NET, Java, JavaScript, PCRE, Perl, Python, Ruby

\R

Regex options: None

Regex flavors: PCRE 7, Perl 5.10

Replacement text flavors: .NET, Java, JavaScript, Perl, PHP, Python, Ruby

Step 3: Replace double
 tags with </p><p>

Search for:

\s*

Regex options: None

Regex flavors: .NET, Java, JavaScript, PCRE, ...

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